

Nomura's leading index of Asian exports

NELI surges to a 16-year high, signaling a boom in Asian export growth.

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Fig. 1: Nomura's leading index of Asian exports



- Nomura's leading index of Asia ex-Japan's aggregate exports, or NELI for short, comprises nine components and has a three-month lead time. NELI has correctly predicted past major turning points and is less distorted by base effects than official export data, making it a good momentum leading indicator of Asia's underlying export growth.
- NELI extended its rising streak, surging to 121 in July and marking the highest reading in 16 years. This suggests Asia's super export growth upcycle will continue into Q3. NELI's rise is becoming a bit more broad-based, driven by a strong upswing in tech-related indicators, but also signs of improvement in overall manufacturing and China demand.
- The AI tech upcycle has been the main engine driving Asian exports. However, with the Strait of Hormuz set to reopen, this should ease supply-chain pressures (though the *normalization process* will likely take several months), reduce economic uncertainty and bolster global aggregate demand, especially for capital goods, supporting a further broadening of Asia's export upcycle beyond the tech sector.

Note: Nomura's export leading index can be found on Bloomberg (see ticker: NMEIXLI). Asia ex-Japan's aggregate (nominal) exports include those of China, Hong Kong, India, Indonesia, South Korea, Malaysia, the Philippines, Singapore, Taiwan and Thailand. China's exports to Hong Kong are excluded due to outsized swings on some occasions that seem unrelated to trade activity. Nomura's export leading index is a weighted (inverse of mean-squared errors) sum of the following Z-score standardized variables: Shanghai Shipping Exchange Containerized Freight Index, China's imports, China's imports from Asia, global semiconductor sales, US manufacturing ISM, S&P EM manufacturing PMI, China RatingDog (formerly Caixin) manufacturing PMI, South Korea's semiconductor exports and Philadelphia Semiconductor index. (For more details on its construction, see *Re-calibrating our Asia export leading index*, 16 August 2022).

Source: IHS Markit, CEIC, Bloomberg and Nomura Global Economics.

Appendix A-1

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